



### Burning of heretics

Watched by the French King Philip II Augustus, a group of Amaurician heretics are burned outside Paris in 1210. Philip II's reign also saw the launch of the Albigensian Crusade against Cathar heretics in southern France.

personal property and were not attached to richly endowed abbeys. The friars were a part of the new urban culture, building churches and schools in the middle of towns and preaching in public squares. To support themselves, they depended on charity, putting them more closely in touch with ordinary people. The Franciscan friars, in particular, sought a return to the simplicity and poverty of the early Church, living among the people, caring for the poor or needy and preaching repentance.

### Heretics and the Inquisition

The Dominican order had its roots in the campaign against the Albigensians, or Cathars, a heretical (holding beliefs contrary to the established teachings of the Church) movement in southern France who believed that the existence of evil contradicted the notion of one benign God. Wearing black and white habits, the Dominicans were dedicated to teaching and preaching, and emphasized religious orthodoxy and obedience to the papacy.

As the papacy came to define Christian doctrine with a new exactitude during the 13–14th centuries, there was a corresponding intolerance of unorthodoxy and of deviants such as the Albigensians. By the Synod of Toulouse in 1229, the ecclesiastical tribunals known as inquisitions had developed into a more formal institution charged with the suppression of heresy.

### Medieval pilgrimage

A group of pilgrims leave Canterbury, site of the shrine of Thomas Becket and a major place of pilgrimage, in a version of the prologue to Geoffrey Chaucer's *The Canterbury Tales*.



» Becket's murder by a group of Henry's knights made him a martyr to the cause of church independence. The shrine containing his relics at Canterbury became a center of pilgrimage for people all over Europe.

By the late 14th century, the Church and the papacy itself were divided. Pope Urban VI, elected in 1378, alienated his supporters in the papal court, and the cardinals responded by electing a rival pope. This "antipope," Clement VII, established his papal court at Avignon in France. A European crisis developed as the German emperor recognized the Roman claimant, the French king supported his rival, and other states and kingdoms took one side or the other. The resulting split, or "Great Schism," between a succession of popes and antipopes undermined the prestige and authority of the papacy; for several years there were three rival claimants. The schism was eventually resolved in 1414 at the Council of Constance, with the pope in Rome recognized as legitimate.

### New devotions

For all its power, the established Church was increasingly cut off from the spiritual life of the growing urban classes. Merchants, craftsmen, and their families could now read and write, ending the clergy's monopoly on the transmission of ideas. These people were often better educated than the clergy, and more open to new forms of religious devotion.

The growing impulse for a more personal, informal relationship with God is expressed in spiritual works such as Thomas à Kempis' *The Imitation of Christ*, published around 1418. These ideals also permeated poetry and art, which began to focus more on "Our Lady," the Virgin Mary. Mary was held to be more approachable and sympathetic than other saints, and the relic of her tunic

at Chartres cathedral was a major attraction for pilgrims from all over Europe. Such holy relics were considered miraculous, capable of inducing cures for all manner of physical and spiritual ills. For the well-to-do, a pilgrimage to a shrine was also a relatively pleasant way of doing penance and, hopefully, earning remission from time in purgatory.

Early in the 13th century, two new religious orders were founded. The Franciscan and Dominican friars were known as mendicants, from the Latin word for "beggars," for they renounced

Staffed by Dominicans, the medieval Inquisition operated mainly in France and Italy. The systematic persecution of heretics—and, increasingly, the persecution of any views that diverged from strict Roman Catholic orthodoxy—was the dark side of the highly organized and efficient medieval Church.



### Large stained glass windows

let light and color flood in to the building, a feature typical of Gothic churches and cathedrals.



### FOUNDER OF THE FRANCISCANS (c. 1180–1226)

### ST. FRANCIS OF ASSISI

The son of a wealthy merchant in the Italian town of Assisi, Francis led a carefree youth. In 1209, he was inspired by a sermon to give away all his possessions. He began to live like a beggar, traveling barefoot, preaching repentance, and aiding the poor. In time he was joined by two companions, and they determined to live by the rule of poverty and simplicity that Christ had given to his apostles. In 1210, Francis gained the blessing of Pope Innocent III for his new order, the Franciscans. By his death in 1226, his followers, inspired by St. Francis' humble and compassionate example, numbered many thousands.

